Week 22

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 6 · LESSON 2

Archaeology

BIG IDEA

The Bible is God's Word, and it is also real history. Archaeology helps show it: finds connected to King David and Pontius Pilate remind us that the Bible describes real people, places and events.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. The signature activity shows how clues like the marker, the color and the surface could date a signature, the way archaeologists date what they find.
2. Ancient cities were rebuilt on the rubble of earlier ones, forming layers called a tell; the deeper archaeologists dig, the further back in time they go.
3. A Lego model in the rubble would date its layer by when that set came out; the question for students is what biblical artifacts mean for the biblical text.
4. The storyteller needn't be an archaeologist; someone who found a family heirloom in an attic works. An artifact makes a story more reliable and more powerful.
5. Small groups focus on the Bible as accurate history: coins point to David as king, and inscriptions show Pontius Pilate was a real governor at Jesus' crucifixion.
6. Expect pushback that it's all stories and myths and be ready to talk it through; then ask students how this evidence changes the way they see the Bible.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. What have I learned these past two weeks that I didn't know before?
2. Am I willing to tell students, "I didn't know this either," and learn alongside them?
3. How does seeing the Bible as real history change the way I read it?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. How can an archaeologist tell when an object was made or used?
2. What does it add to a story when there's an object or artifact to go with it?
3. Why does it matter that people like David and Pontius Pilate were real?
4. What pushback have you heard about the Bible being just stories or myths, and how would you answer it?
5. Two weeks in, how has this evidence changed the way you see the Bible?

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WEEK 22 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

The signature activity

0:06 This week we're talking about archaeology, and in the introduction activity we asked your students to produce their signature — kind of a strange thing to do, right? So, do your signature. There's my mess of a signature, and we asked them to do that multiple times. Well, why? Because when an archaeologist is digging — and what archaeologists do is, if you have an excavation site, you have to dig below. Well, what happens when a city falls? It crumbles to the ground; it all falls in.

0:46 It's not like today, where if this whole entire building came down, we would clear the rubble, send it to recycling facilities, rebuild, level the ground and start all over again. They didn't have those capabilities. So if a city fell and all the rubble sat here, they would simply level off the rubble and build a new city right on top. And they kept doing that year after year after year, or decade after decade, or whatever the case may be.

1:17 So as archaeologists are digging, they're digging below each of these levels. Each one is called — it's an archaeological tell, is what they call it. And they're digging into, well, they have to use clues to figure out that if they started digging here and found something, that's going to be from a different time period than if they dug down here and found something.

1:43 So the signature is a way to help your students understand that if they found a piece of paper with my signature on it, and they figured out that it was me with this big mess of a signature, they would know that — let's see — based on the fact that I used an Expo marker, the fact that I'm on a whiteboard, the fact that it's black, all these factors, plus the fact that they would connect it to me, they could figure out roughly the date, or at least get close to when this actually happened. Let me give you another example.

A Lego illustration

2:19 This is the Hulkbuster, and full disclosure, this is mine, not my kids'. If this whole building collapsed — let's say we were in ancient times and they had Legos in ancient times — and this whole building collapsed, and they found pieces of this and put it back together and discovered that it was this, then based on the kind of Lego this is, based on the character, the fact that this is Iron Man in the Hulkbuster suit, they would pretty much know exactly when this Lego came out, roughly when it got built, and what era they're currently digging in.

2:59 So that's the importance, and that's kind of what archaeologists do. We want your students to start thinking about what that looks like. This isn't necessarily Indiana Jones kind of stuff, but it gives us a good idea of how this is done. So when they come across biblical artifacts, what does that mean for the biblical text?

Finding a storyteller

3:18 For your storyteller, this is a really cool opportunity to have someone come in. You don't have to have an archaeologist, and you don't have to have anybody who has made an amazing discovery. If you can, that would be awesome. If you happen to have somebody at a local seminary who has done some traveling to the Middle East and Jerusalem and whatnot, that would be awesome. But if not, that's okay — don't worry like you have to have that. You could simply have somebody who was rummaging around in grandma's attic and found a really important family heirloom.

3:50 Years ago, my grandma was moving from her condo to a long-term care facility, because she was getting ill and needed to be watched pretty much 24-7. So my family all got together and we were going through all of her stuff. That's a little bit weird when she's sitting there watching us go through all of her stuff. But it was fascinating, because we found all these really cool artifacts, and there were stories behind them. It was stuff that reminded my dad of his childhood and of what that meant, and we talked about really interesting stories and had a really great time walking down those memories.

4:27 But if you could just find a storyteller to even tell that story, it helps connect the importance of discovery and archaeology and artifacts and all those pieces of history with what we can know about the Bible. Because my dad can tell me a story, but when he connects it with an artifact or something from his past, that story becomes that much more reliable — because otherwise it could just be that he remembered it wrong. It also becomes that much more powerful, because I'm understanding that what he's telling me is now actually history. And that's exactly what we're hoping your students get when they look at archaeology and Scripture.

Small group focus

5:07 So for small groups, your focus is simple. I want you to focus on helping students see that this Bible is also history. Yes, it's the Word of God. Yes, it's inspired. Yes, it's completely accurate in every way, because God made it that way. But God also made this an accurate reflection of history. What goes on in here is actually historical.

5:38 We have found coins that give us indication that David actually was a king. And we've seen things from the New Testament that have the inscription of Pontius Pilate on them, reminding us that Pontius Pilate was an actual person. He was an actual governor. He actually was the one responsible during Jesus's crucifixion. There is history behind it all.

Be ready for questions

6:07 We want your students to drill that in, but I also want you to pay attention to their questions. Now that they're starting to see Scripture as something a little bit more important than maybe they thought it was, there's going to be some pushback, and some thought that, well, isn't this just a bunch of stories and myths that maybe people thought were true? And there's some sort of evidence that maybe they just messed around with history, and they just messed around

with the truth a little bit. There are going to be questions, and you need to be ready to answer those questions and talk through them a little bit.

One final question

6:35 But I want you to continue to walk students down that road of helping them understand and see the importance of this book and what it means for their lives. So I'm going to leave you with one final question that I want you to leave your students with. Two weeks in, what does this information, from biblical reliability to archaeological evidence, do for how you see the Bible?

7:06 Think about that for yourself, because if you didn't know some of this information prior to these last couple of weeks, and now you're moving forward with your students — think about that with yourself. Does this change how you see it? And don't be afraid to share this with your students and help them see, hey, I didn't know either. Maybe I didn't know all of this. This is new information for you as well. Share that with your students.

7:30 Walk alongside them, and especially encourage your small group leaders to do the same thing, so that they can see that this isn't something they ought to know, that everybody should know, and they're just kind of out of the loop — this is a journey for all of you. And the more you understand, the greater this book becomes.